
fishtail
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GAME COMPONENTS



34 Fish Cards



5 Bait Dice



20 Boats (5 per color)



Fish Token



1 Score Card



1 Tackle Box



1 Turn Card



32 Bait Cards

REFERENCE

Fish Cards
What you catch and how you score points

Dice
How to determine what you can catch

Boats
Used to Bid for Fishing spots

Fish Token
Whoever has it starts the round

Score Card
Reference for how to count points

Turn Card
Reference to what you can do on your turn

Bait Cards
Add to the dice to help you catch fish

THE STORY

The lake changes from season to season.

Fish gather and move without warning, and the best fishing spots are never guaranteed to stay open. Anglers return each year to find new opportunities and compete for the most valuable catches.

Each player takes the role of an angler, choosing where to fish and when to commit their boats. Some spots will draw more attention than others, and control of a good location can make the difference between success and failure.

Even in the right place, a catch is never certain. The available bait determines what can be caught, and not every attempt will succeed.

Choose your spots carefully and make the most of each season on the lake.

OVERVIEW & GOAL

In Fishtail, players compete to control fishing spots and catch fish by meeting their bait requirements.

Each season, players place boats to gain control of fish in the lake while also shaping the available bait by rolling dice into the Tackle Box. Controlling a fish gives you the opportunity to catch it, but success depends on whether the shared bait matches that fish's requirements.

At the end of each season, fish are resolved one at a time. The player with the most boats on a fish controls it and is the only player who may attempt to catch it. To do so, the bait dice in the Tackle Box must match the requirements shown on the fish. If they do not, that player may spend bait cards to make up the difference. If the requirements are met, the fish is caught. If not, it is discarded.

Players earn points by catching fish, building set bonuses, and using their resources efficiently.

The game ends after the season in which any player catches their 5th fish. All fish in that final season are resolved before scoring, but every player must discard down to 5.

SETUP

Prepare the lake, distribute boats, and get ready for the first season.

Cards

After Shuffling, place the Decks of Fish Cards and Bait Cards in the center of the play area face down, each in one pile. Set the Tackle Box card next to the play area.

Dice

Place the dice in the center of the play area next to the cards.

Boats

Give each player 5 Boats of a color.

Fish Token

Give the Fish Token (First Player Marker) to the player who most recently went fishing.



SEASON OVERVIEW

Fishtail is played over a series of seasons. Each season represents one complete round of play, from setting up the lake to resolving all catches.

Core Structure

Each season is divided into three phases:

1. Start of Season

New fish are added to the lake, increasing the available fishing spots for the round.

2. Casting Phase

Players take turns placing boats, revealing fish, and rolling bait dice into the Tackle Box.

During this phase:

- Players compete to control fish using boats
- Players decide when to reveal hidden fish
- Players roll bait dice one at a time into the shared Tackle Box
- The Tackle Box gradually defines what can be caught this season

Players may also pass once they are finished for the round. Once all players have passed, Casting ends.

3. Catch Phase

Each fish is resolved one at a time.

For each fish:

- The player with the most boats on that fish gains control
- Only that player may attempt to resolve the catch
- The bait dice in the Tackle Box must match the fish's requirements
- If the dice are insufficient, bait cards may be spent to complete the requirement
- If requirements are not met, the fish is discarded

After each fish is resolved, boats are returned and the process continues until all fish have been checked.

Start of Season → Casting Phase → Catch Phase → Next Season

1. START OF SEASON

Each season begins by building the lake. This determines the fishing spots available for the round.

Sequence

Follow these steps in order:

1. Reveal 1 Fish card from the deck and place it face-up in the center of the play area.
2. Deal additional Fish cards face-down to the lake equal to the number of players.
3. Place these cards face-down around the central Fish to form the lake.
4. These face-down Fish are part of the lake and may be revealed during the Casting phase.

Note: The lake always contains 1 Fish for the number of players + 1. Here is an example for a **3-player game**



What This Means

Each season introduces new Fish, and most remain hidden until players choose to reveal them.

Face-Down Fish

Face-down Fish are part of the lake. They may be revealed during the Casting phase, creating new opportunities and increasing competition.

Once revealed, they function exactly like face-up Fish.

2. CASTING

During Casting, players compete for control of fish while building the bait conditions that will be used in the Catch phase.

Turn Structure

Starting with the first player, play proceeds clockwise. On your turn, choose one action:

A) Place Boats

Place one or more of your Boats onto a face-up Fish.

Rules:

- You may place Boats on only one Fish per turn.
- To place Boats on a Fish, you must place enough Boats to have more than any other player on that Fish.
- You may place boats on Fish that other players have already placed on.
- Boats may only be placed on face-up Fish

B) Reveal a Fish

Choose one face-down Fish in the lake and flip it face-up.

- Revealed Fish immediately become available for Boats.

C) Roll a Bait Die

Roll one Bait Die that is not in the Tackle Box and then add into the Tackle Box.

- All rolled dice remain in the Tackle Box for the rest of the season.
- If the 5th die is placed into the Tackle Box, the player who rolled it takes the Start Token.

D) Pass

You may only pass if the Tackle Box contains all 5 Bait Dice.

- You may not re-enter Casting this season.

End of Casting

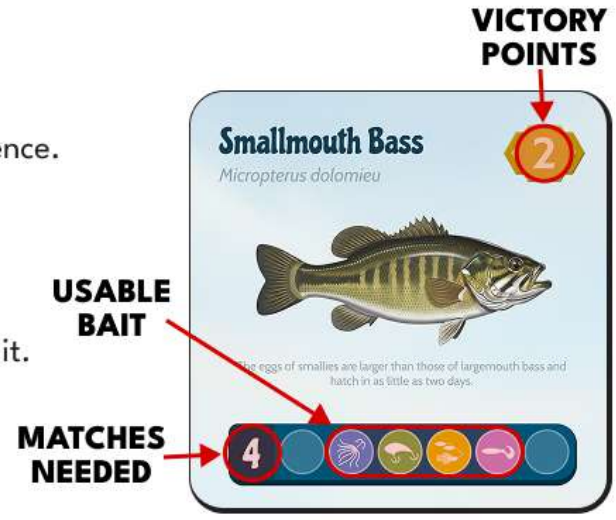
Casting continues until all players have passed, then proceed to the Catch phase.

3. THE CATCH

In the Catch phase, each Fish is resolved one at a time. Success depends on meeting bait requirements.

How to Catch Fish

Attempt to catch Fish one at a time in a clear sequence.
For each fish, follow these steps:



1. Determine Control

The player with the most Boats on the Fish controls it.

- If no Boats are present, discard the Fish.

2. Check Bait Requirements

Each Fish shows a number of required bait matches and the types of bait that can be used.
The Bait Dice in the Tackle Box are compared to the Fish's requirements.

- Each matching die counts as 1 requirement met
- Only dice in the Tackle Box are used at this stage

3. Use Bait Cards (if needed)

If the requirement is not fully met using dice, the player attempting to catch the fish may spend Bait Cards to complete the missing requirements.

- Each Bait Card counts as 1 bait
- The bait type on the card must match a required bait icon on the Fish
- Bait Cards are spent only for the Fish being resolved

4. Resolve Outcome

If all requirements are met, the controlling player catches the Fish and keeps it.

- If requirements are not met, the Fish is discarded

End of Phase

After all Fish have been resolved, The Catch phase ends

If any player has caught their 5th Fish, the game ends after this full resolution. Otherwise, start a new Season

SCORING & WINNING

At the end of the game, players score points from the fish they have caught and from additional bonuses earned during play.

End of Game

The game ends after the Catch phase of the season in which any player catches their 5th Fish. Complete the resolution of all Fish in that season before scoring begins. All players must discard down to their limit of 5 Fish

Scoring

Each player calculates their total score from three categories:

1. Fish Points

Add the point value shown on each Fish card you have successfully caught. Each Fish is worth the value printed on its card.

2. Bait Set Points

You score bonus points for collecting sets of Fish with matching bait icons.
Scoring rules for sets are shown on the Scoring Card.

- Identify groups of Fish with shared bait symbols
- Score based on the set values shown on the Scoring Card

3. Live Bait Bonus

You gain additional 5 points if you have the most Live Bait symbols on your fish.

3. Victory Point Bait Cards

Some Bait Cards have Victory Points instead of Bait.

Winning the Game

After all scoring is complete, the player with the highest total score wins. If players are still tied, the player with the most Bait Cards in their hand is the winner.

EXAMPLE ROUND

This example shows how a full season of play unfolds, from placing boats to resolving catches.

Start of Season

4 players are playing: Aliana, Benny, Christie, and David

There are 5 Fish in the lake: 1 face-up (Bluegill), 4 face-down (1 for each player)

Casting

Turn 1

- Aliana rolls a Bait Die and places it into the Tackle Box.
- Benny places 2 Boats on the Bluegill.
- Christie chooses to reveal a face-down Fish (Common Carp).
- David places 3 Boats on the Bluegill, taking control away from Benny.

Fast-Forward to Turn 5

- Aliana reveals the last face-down Fish (Largemouth Bass).
- Benny places 1 Boat on the Common Carp.
- Christie rolls the final Bait Die and places it into the Tackle Box, taking the Fish Token.
- David passes.

Players continue until all Fish Dice are in the Tackle Box or all players pass.

Since Christie had 1 boat left over after passing, she gets to draw 1 bait card.

The Catch

The Bait Dice show: Live, Live, Jig, Jerk, and Spoon.

Benny controls the Common Carp, which requires a combined total of two Live, Jig, or Plastic Bait. Since there are 2 Live Baits and 1 Jig, then the Fish is easily caught.

Christie controls the Lake Sturgeon, which requires three Live Bait. Since there are only 2 Live Baits then the Fish can't be caught. However, she has a bait card that happens to be live bait. She uses the bait card to catch the fish.

David controls the Bluegill, which requires a combined total of two Live or Plastic Bait. Since there are 2 Live Baits, then the Fish is caught!

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What happens if no one places Boats on a Fish?
If a Fish has no Boats on it during the Catch phase, it is discarded and no one scores it.

Can I use the same Bait Card on multiple Fish?
No. Each bait card can only be used for one Fish.

Do Bait Dice get removed after each Fish is resolved?
No. All Bait Dice remain in the Tackle Box for the entire season unless otherwise stated.

Can Bait Cards be saved for later?
Yes. Unused Bait Cards carry over during the season, but they are only used during Catch resolution and are spent when used.

Do Bait Cards need to match specific icons?
Yes. A Bait Card can only replace a missing requirement if its icon matches one of the Fish's required bait types.

Can I place Boats on multiple Fish in one turn?
No. You may only place Boats on one Fish per turn.

Do Boats return after each Fish?
Yes. After each Fish is resolved, all Boats are returned to their owners.

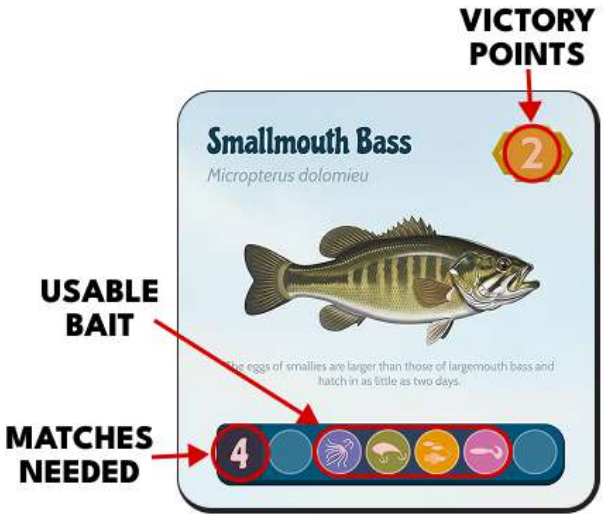
When exactly does the game end?
The game ends after the Catch phase in which a player catches their 5th Fish. All remaining Fish in that season are fully resolved before scoring.

What if multiple players reach 5 Fish in the same season?
All Fish in that season are resolved. The final score determines the winner.

QUICK REFERENCE

Setup

- Place Tackle Box in center
- Shuffle Fish deck
- Reveal 1 face-up Fish
- Add # of players of face-down Fish to the lake
- Each player takes 5 Boats
- Place 5 Bait Dice in center
- Determine starting player



Rounds

1. Start of Season

Add new Fish to the lake

2. Casting Phase

Players take turns to:

- Place Boats
- Reveal Fish
- Roll Bait Dice
- Pass

Casting ends when all players pass.

3. Catch Phase

Draw Bait Cards

Resolve Fish one at a time:

- Determine control
- Check bait dice vs requirements
- Use Bait Cards if needed
- Catch or discard Fish
- Return Boats after each Fish

End of Game

The game ends after the season in which a player catches their 5th Fish.

- Finish resolving all Fish in that season
- Then proceed to scoring